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A refinery in the Yasuní region of Ecuador’s rainforest. Drilling expanded after a plan to keep oil reserves untouched lost global support.

Ecuador Tried to Curb Drilling. The Reverse Happened.

By CATRIN EINHORN
and MANUELA ANDREONI

YASUNÍ NATIONAL PARK, Ecuador — In a swath of lush Amazon rainforest here, near some of the last Indigenous people on Earth living in isolation, workers recently finished building a new oil platform carved out of the wilderness. Teams are drilling in one of the most environmentally important ecosystems on the planet, one that stores vast amounts of planet-warming carbon. They’re moving gradually closer to an off-limits zone meant to shield the Indigenous groups. It turns out that

some of the country’s largest oil reserves are found here, too. Ecuador is short of cash and struggling with debt. The government sees drilling as its best way out. The story of this place, Yasuní National Park, offers a case study on how global financial forces continue to trap developing countries into depleting some of the most biodiverse places on the planet. Countries like Ecuador are “against the wall,” said María Fernanda Espinosa, an Ecuadorean diplomat and a former president of the United Nations General Assembly. Drilling in this part of the rainforest wasn’t Ecuador’s first

Using Oil to Ease Debt at Rainforest’s Cost

choice. In 2007, Rafael Correa, the president at the time, proposed a novel alternative that would have kept the oil reserves in a parcel here designated as Block 43, estimated then at around a billion barrels, in the ground. Under that plan, countries would have created a fund of \$3.6 billion, half of the oil’s estimated value, to compensate Ecuador for leaving its reserves untouched. Supporters of the idea said it

would have been a win for the climate, for biodiversity and for Indigenous rights. And, they said, it would have been a precedent-setting moral victory: A small, developing nation would have been paid for giving up a resource that helped make places like the United States and Europe so wealthy. But, after early fanfare, only a pittance in contributions trickled in. Ecuador turned to China for loans, around \$8 billion over the course of the Correa administration, some to be repaid in oil. The failure of that plan led to the current expansion of drilling in

Biden Inquiry Puts Spotlight On Winter ’17

The Frenetic Last Days of a Vice Presidency

By PETER BAKER
and MICHAEL D. SHEAR

WASHINGTON — Those last days were a blur of phone calls, meetings, farewell events and visits to Ukraine and Switzerland. As he wrapped up his tenure as vice president in January 2017, Joseph R. Biden Jr. was packing in as much as he could.

The question now is, what else was being packed? And by whom? And why? And where was it going?

The appointment of a special counsel has focused new attention on Mr. Biden’s frenetic final stretch in the White House after eight years as the No. 2 to President Barack Obama. Somehow, a small number of classified documents would go not to the archives, where they belonged, but to Mr. Biden’s home in Wilmington, Del., and, later, a private office in Washington, where they did not.

With Mr. Biden back in the White House, he finds himself struggling to explain what happened. His administration kept the discovery of sensitive records secret from the public for two months until media reports revealed it, and has had to update its version of events multiple times over the last week. On Saturday, the White House said that after previously reporting that one page of classified material had been found in a room next to the garage at the Wilmington house, five more pages were discovered by Justice Department personnel who had come to collect the material.

Robert K. Hur, who was named

Continued on Page 16

MORE FILES FOUND A total of six pages have been discovered, the White House says. PAGE 16

SANTOS’S DECEITS WEREN’T A SECRET IN G.O.P. CIRCLES

RED FLAGS SEEN IN ’21

Campaign Vetting Report Led Aides to Quit, and Party Had Doubts

By NICHOLAS FANDOS

In late 2021, as he prepared to make a second run for a suburban New York City House seat, George Santos gave permission for his campaign to commission a routine background study on him.

Campaigns frequently rely on this kind of research, known as vulnerability studies, to identify anything problematic that an opponent might seize on. But when the report came back on Mr. Santos, the findings by a Washington research firm were far more startling, suggesting a pattern of deception that cut to the heart of the image he had cultivated as a wealthy financier.

Some of Mr. Santos’s own vendors were so alarmed after seeing the study in late November 2021 that they urged him to drop out of the race, and warned that he could risk public humiliation by continuing. When Mr. Santos disputed key findings and vowed to continue running, members of the campaign team quit, according to three of the four people The New York Times spoke to with knowledge of the study. The episode, which has not been previously reported, is the most explicit evidence to date that a small circle of well-connected Republican campaign professionals had indications far earlier than the public that Mr. Santos was spinning an elaborate web of deceptions, and that the candidate himself had been warned about just how vulnerable those lies were to unraveling.

Fraudulent academic degrees. Involvement in a firm accused of a Ponzi scheme. Multiple evictions and a suspended driver’s license. All of it was in the report, which also said that Mr. Santos, who is openly gay, had been married to a woman. The report did not offer conclusive details, but some people briefed on the findings wondered whether the marriage was done for immigration purposes. It remains unclear who else, if anyone, learned about the background study’s contents at the time, or if the information made its way to party leaders in New York or Washington. Mr. Santos, 34, managed to keep almost all of it from the public until after he was elected, when an investigation by The Times independently unearthed the problematic claims documented by researchers and others that they missed. After The Times sent a detailed list of questions for this article, a lawyer for Mr. Santos, Joe Murray, said “it would be inappropriate to respond due to ongoing investigations.” A spokeswoman for Mr. Santos’s congressional office did not respond to a similar request

Continued on Page 18

Plundering Art, Russia Assaults Soul of Ukraine

By JEFFREY GETTLEMAN
and OLEKSANDRA MYKOLYSHYN

KHERSON, Ukraine — One morning in late October, Russian forces blocked off a downtown street and surrounded a graceful old building with dozens of soldiers.

Five large trucks pulled up. So did a line of military vehicles, ferrying Russian agents who filed in through several doors. It was a carefully planned, highly organized, military-style assault — on an art museum.

Over the next four days, the Kherson Regional Art Museum was cleaned out, witnesses said, with Russian forces “bustling about like insects,” porters wheeling out thousands of paintings, soldiers hastily wrapping them in sheets, art experts barking out orders and packing material flying everywhere.

“They were loading such masterpieces, which there are no more in the world, as if they were garbage,” said the museum’s long-time director, Alina Dotsenko, who recently returned from exile, recounting what employees and witnesses had told her.

When she came back to the museum in early November and grasped how much had been stolen, she said, “I almost lost my mind.”

Kherson. Mariupol. Melitopol. Kakhovsky. Museums of art, history and antiquities.

As Russia has ravaged Ukraine

Continued on Page 10



JOHN BURCHAM FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES



MARCUS WESTBERG



ANDY HASLAM FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES



PORAS CHAUDHARY FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

52 Places to Go in 2023

The return of travel has shown the depth of our drive to explore. With destinations like Arizona, Algeria, Scotland, Japan, India and more, this year’s list offers inspiration. Special Section.



ANDREW FAULK FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

As Historical Dramas Mushroom, So Do Complaints About Their Inaccuracies

By JEREMY W. PETERS
and NICOLE SPERLING

The following stories are not based on real events. In fact, they’re made up — even though they’re meant to seem real.

No, Queen Elizabeth’s staff never hid a copy of The Sunday Times from her because of a nonexistent front-page headline:

“Queen Should Abdicate in Favour of Prince of Wales — Half of British Public Agrees.”

No, the former Los Angeles Lakers head coach Jerry West didn’t fly into fits of rage so violent that he snapped a putter over his knee and tossed his Most Valuable Player trophy through a window in his office.

And no, the two police officers

who unwittingly missed an opportunity to arrest Jeffrey Dahmer before he could kill again were not given honors as officers of the year by the Milwaukee Police Department.

But the millions of people who watched three of the most popular historical dramas of the last year — “The Crown” and “Monster: The Jeffrey Dahmer Story” on

Netflix and HBO’s “Winning Time: The Rise of the Lakers Dynasty” — were left to separate fact from fiction on their own.

These series are hardly outliers in the flourishing genre of based-on-a-true-story entertainment.

As the number of shows and movies that depict real events has grown in recent years — never before have dramatizations of well-

known people and events been so popular and prevalent — so, too, have the liberties that screenwriters are taking with the facts.

In many instances, these are not mere embellishments for dramatic flair but major fabrications. Some of the people who claim they’ve been reduced to crude caricatures onscreen are suing for

Continued on Page 15

NATIONAL 14-22

Manhattan D.A. Looks Ahead

Alvin L. Bragg finished his stormy first year in office with a conviction of the Trump Organization, but he must still contend with rising crime. PAGE 14

Another Wallop for California

Thousands are under evacuation orders as more storms inundate the state, leaving roads impassable, downing power lines and swelling rivers. PAGE 22

New York Stadium’s True Price

Mayor Eric Adams says a new soccer arena won’t cost city taxpayers anything, but a new analysis puts the actual cost at \$516 million. PAGE 19



INTERNATIONAL 4-13

Italy’s Ruthless Truffle Wars

The competition for culinary “black gold” has led rivals to poison hunters’ beloved fungus-sniffing dogs. PAGE 4

German Climate Standoff Ends

The police removed activists and the village of Lützerath was razed to make way for an open-pit coal mine. PAGE 8

ARTS & LEISURE

Gambling on a Zombie Story

Hollywood has mostly failed to smartly adapt video games into series and films. The creators of “The Last of Us” argue that it’s an exception. PAGE 18

SPORTS 26-29

Where’s the Catch?

What Justin Jefferson, Tyreek Hill and three other top N.F.L. receivers have to say about the science and art of running routes. PAGE 26

SUNDAY OPINION

Jamelle Bouie

PAGE 3



SUNDAY STYLES

Young at Heart, Ready to Rock

A group of die-hard music fans, almost all over 65, make the “Geezer Happy Hour” a joyful dance party. PAGE 1

A Day Without Plastic

In a 24-hour experiment, a journalist tried to go plastic-free. That meant no toothpaste, bed or phone. PAGE 8

SUNDAY BUSINESS

How Much Do You Earn?

We asked nearly 400 people on the streets of New York to tell us how much they make. Some of them actually told us. Here are the numbers. PAGE 6

METROPOLITAN

The Struggle of Uber Drivers

Fees and inflation cut into falling earnings while many must still pay off cars used for dwindling work. PAGE 1



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